

The real thing that needs to happen is we need to figure out how to extract the information, the data. So there's gotta be ways where it can be more consistent, and that's what I would really... is more important than anything is actually getting actual data. So do we have to do it through a browser control, or you tell me

Claude responded: Good question — and "you tell me" is the right instinct to ask, because there are real trade-offs.

Thought process

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Good question — and "you tell me" is the right instinct to ask, because there are real trade-offs. Let me lay out the landscape honestly before recommending anything.

What's actually reliable for free

YouTube → YouTube Data API v3 is the single biggest win available. It's completely free (10,000 units/day quota), gives you exact subscriber counts, video counts, view counts, upload dates — everything. Right now yt-dlp is guessing at this. Switching to the official API would make YouTube rock-solid. You just need a free Google Cloud account.

Website copy → Playwright (headless browser) instead of Tavily extract. Playwright is free, open-source, renders JavaScript, and doesn't get blocked by SSL issues the way Tavily does. It's what browser automation tools use under the hood. This fixes the **ibanez.com** class of problem completely.

Instagram → instaloader is already the best free option, but it needs smarter retry + rate-limit handling. The problem isn't the tool, it's that it gives up on the first failure instead of backing off and retrying.

TikTok → this is the hard one. There is no reliable free TikTok data source. The honest options are: keep Tavily search as a signal (it's imperfect but not zero), or accept that TikTok data will be sparse unless you pay Apify ~\$50/mo.

Facebook — the Meta Ad Library API is free, it just needs a properly configured access token. Right now it may be hitting auth issues.

What about browser control (Claude in Chrome)?

You could use it for website copy extraction as a fallback — it's essentially Playwright under the hood. But it's interactive and slow, so it's better as a manual fallback for specific blocked sites than as a bulk data pipeline.

My recommended priority order

1. **YouTube Data API v3** — free, immediate, biggest data quality jump
2. **Playwright for website copy** — fixes the SSL blocking problem at the root
3. **Better instaloader error handling** — stop returning 0 on first failure
4. **Meta Ad Library auth fix** — free data you're already trying to pull